

Incident Alert 0019. TLP Green.			Date	Breakout Scale
Title	FR, BE – Unlabelled Political ads attacking Al Jazeera journalist published by hijacked Facebook page		09/07/2024	2

Summary

- A seemingly hijacked Facebook page published 6 ads attacking an Al Jazeera journalist.
- The ads are a part of a campaign that we and other researchers have previously reported on.
- The ads reached a total of 197k Facebook users in France and Brussels.
- The ads use obfuscation to hide keywords from Meta's automated content moderation.
- Ads and page reported to Meta and European governments.

Incident – When, Who did what, to say what, to whom, why?

On July 8, the Facebook page Radioscoutakouda published 6 ads with an image with text on attacking the Al Jazeera journalist Jalal Chahda ([1](#)). The ad targeted France, the Belgian city of Brussels, and two non-EU countries that are not disclosed by Meta. The ads are placed on Facebook, Instagram, and Meta Audience Network. The page was created in 2013 ([2](#)), made its last post in 2015 ([3](#)), and seemingly belonged to an online armature radio station. The ad obfuscated the word “terrorist” by whiting out a part of the word.

In incident alerts 0013 and 0014, two other pages ran unlabelled political ads with videos attacking Qatar. This seems to belong to the Coordinated inauthentic behaviour network outlined by Marc Owen Jones and Sohan Dsouza ([4](#)). Attribution is not known.

Narrative

Meta narrative: Qatar is harming Europe
Sub-Narrative: Al Jazeera journalist support terrorists.

Impact

Reach: France: 168,095, Brussels: 29,013.
Interactions with the ads posts: 460. Comments: 24. Shares: 4. By seemingly authentic users.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective: [Smear](#) – Smearing the reputation of the Al Jazeera journalist.
[Deliver Ads](#) – Using ads to reach their target audience without revealing the ads' funding source.
[Conceal network identity](#) - the page seems to be hiding its true identity and affiliations.
[Acquire Compromised Account](#) – Likely acquired a compromised account and page to post the ads.
[Manipulate Platform Algorithm](#) – Obfuscated a keyword to avoid Meta's automated content moderation.

Recommendations

- Action Taken: Meta and European governments alerted on the July 9, around 01:00.
- Meta should try to put safeguards in place to stop compromised Facebook pages from posting ads.
- Meta should also extend their transparency measures to also include countries outside the EU.

Report	Topic	Evidence	Authors	Content type	Platforms
N/A	Qatar, Islam, Ads.	N/A	Saman Nazari , Alliance4Europe	Ads, Post	Meta